

SHAPE OF MOMO (Sikkim)

Tribeny Rai's assured directorial debut feature is solid proof of how the personal is universal. Through her deep exploration of female bonds and portrait of a woman's silent rebellion against patriarchy, Rai also shows how Sikkim's landscape is changing.

BOONG (Manipur)

Lakshmipriya Devi's affecting drama centres on a child that you can't help but root for. Through Boong's search for his father, Devi lays bare the harsh realities of Manipuri society yet manages to show that, amidst the turmoil, there is always cause for hope.

upon winning the award in London. "*Boong* is not only rooted in a place which is very troubled [but also] very ignored and unrepresented in India."

If there is a pattern, it's that the Northeast is making itself heard. Rai and Devi are just two of the many filmmakers putting films from the lesser-represented states on the national and international map. Just in February, another northeastern film, *Not A Hero*, about a boy moving from the bustle of the city to a quaint ancestral village, got a special mention at the Berlin International Film Festival. Director Rima Das is a festival darling, with her films about Assam's young and restless touring the world. This group represents a growing legion of ingenious, independent voices from the northeastern states that is not just introducing their audiences to the region's scenic topography, but offering realistic peeks into local lives and incisively dissecting the issues that affect them.



"NORTHEASTERN FILMMAKERS ARE MOSTLY COMPLAINING ABOUT MISREPRESENTATION. IF YOU WANT TO BE THE HERO OF YOUR STORY, TAKE THE REINS IN YOUR HAND"

TRIBENY RAI
Filmmaker

TOUGH ROAD AHEAD

Funding and distribution, however, remain a challenge for the region's indie filmmakers. They don't have the backing of big studios and have an entertainment ecosystem that is diminutive compared to Bollywood and the ones in the South. Rai relied on her mother's retirement fund and her own savings as a freelance filmmaker to bankroll *Shape of Momo*. Assam's Bhaskar Hazarika, known for *Aamis* (2019), about a thirtysomething doctor and a young PhD student's unorthodox relationship, has his own company, Metanormal Pictures. But he feels northeastern governments need to ramp up efforts to create an enabling environment for independent filmmakers. He says, "Cinema has always been one of the strongest of soft powers and it's time the government recognises this."

It's a testament to the neglect faced by films from the region when one looks at the fate of *Rapture*, a Garo-language film about a village gripped in fear after the recent disappearances of local children, directed by Meghalaya's Dominic Sangma. The film found a theatrical release in over 100 cinemas in France in 2024 but didn't get one in its homeland. So, Sangma and one of his producers, Eva Gunme R. Marak, went about find-